For all we know, we'll reach counting day, March 10, without a single sloganeering convoy having disturbed the air anywhere.

All the din will be digital. That means a fundamental shift in campaign strategies. In recent years, all political parties have evolved a strong digital side to their public outreach—backroom geniuses working with databases and worksheets are now critical elements everywhere. But this time, circumstances dictate that the arena will be entirely virtual. Parties are being forced to beef up their Digital War Rooms: it is here that micro-trends will have to be tracked, slogans created and disseminated, tactics shaped and reshaped.

The sudden adjustment has not been easy for old-style satraps—afflicted as they are with digital arthritis, symptoms ranging from mild to severe. In UP, there's a rush to hire social media professionals. One state Congress leader has asked his team to reactivate his Twitter account—he had stopped using it last year after losing interest in social media! A Samajwadi Party leader has hired a team to spruce up her social media accounts and advise her on Twitter trends. The sudden uptick in demand means IT professionals and freelancers are making hay—some have got so many assignments that they are working the morning shift for the BJP, then moonlighting for the Samajwadis. Both sides are forced to wink at the practice. For the geeks, the running joke is that "Netaji is learning Twitter". Ironical though it may seem, the farmer unions in Punjab, wading into battle themselves, seem more tech-savvy.

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The BJP, the incumbent in four of these five states, has the most formidable digital arsenal. But it will be bereft of something it has relied on as its prime weapon: the charismatic figure of Narendra Modi working the crowds like an Indian Mandrake. Like all classic public performers, he is in his truest element in front of a live crowd. The Congress, hoping to blood Priyanka Gandhi in her first full-fledged state elections in UP, will likewise lose out on the aura of presence. Indeed, across parties there are politicians who have honed their craft for the old economy, as it were. Take Mamata Banerjee, for instance, gatecrashing into Goa with a *tatta* platter full of promises. Or the garrulous Navjot Sidhu. Or Arvind Kejriwal, with his plainspoken vibes.

In a sense, all parties will experience what it feels like to be in an online classroom. With the high decibels of physical campaigns taken away, how do they stack up? Here's a party-wise comparison of what will fuel India's first digital-only campaign, a sneak peek at the Digital War Rooms:

BJP: MACHINE LEARNING

All five state units of the BJP are battle-ready with IT cells in every state and district, guided by a central team. In all, over eight million party workers are linked to this giant digital outreach machinery. The party has seven morchas—OBC, Muslim, Dalit, Tribals, Youth, Women, Kisan—which have their own state, district and mandal units. All have their own WhatsApp groups reaching the very bottom of the pyramid, in some cases right down to booth level. The party is now using this digital brigade to intensify content dissemination: Facebook and microblogging sites like Twitter and Koo too are prime channels.

In UP alone, the BJP has conducted at least 85 meetings and workshops for over 9,000 of its social media functionaries in the last six months. In the second week of January itself, over a lakh WhatsApp groups were created at booth level in UP. Over 100 Facebook pages have been dedicated to different districts. The digital army is divided into two battalions—one for social media, the other for information technology—with their 11,000 office-bearers assigned to 1,918 mandals in the state. "At every mandal, we have a team of five office-bearers—three from social media, two from IT," says an apparatchik. This covers the six zones the state has been divided into by the BJP digital czars, each zone overseen by a team of four. "Opposition parties don't even know the difference between 'IT team' and 'social media team', they have only one team," laughs Kameshwar Nath Mishra, IT cell in-charge of Uttar Pradesh BJP. 'IT cell' commonly denotes the party's social media content producers; he is making the distinction between those who make those ubiquitous WhatsApp memes and those who ensure the channels of dissemination are smooth and well-oiled—infotech proper. Once the content is created, within 24 hours it reaches all the desired phones in the local language. The party had done a dry run of the new network during the Covid lockdown with the PM Garib Kalyan Yojana free ration distribution. Now that machinery is being deployed in full to build brand Yogi.

In Punjab, the BJP has gone to town with the slogan '*Nawa Punjab Bhajapa naal* (New Punjab with BJP)'. It has also launched its 'NRI4NewPunjab' campaign—with over 10,000 WhatsApp groups and 5,000-odd groups on Telegram and Signal linking NRIs to their native homesteads, and discussing work done by the Centre and BJP state governments elsewhere. To steer this social media fusillade, the BJP has stationed some 50 footsoldiers in Chandigarh. In Uttarakhand, not an easy state to cover with physical campaigns anyway, the BJP has developed a digital central command whose job is to get teams active at the mandal level, armed with enticing social media candyfloss, voice-and-text forwards, even SMS blasts. A dry run happens with every session of the PM's Mann ki Baat. In the last one year, the party has created WhatsApp groups at booth, constituency, mandal and district levels. Local MLAs and office-bearers are fully active in this sphere of dizzying action. In Goa, a team of 100 does the honours—projecting the bypasses at Cancona and Old Goa, the bridge on Zuari river and the rejuvenation of Mayem lake; pushing the tagline '*10 varsa samruddhichi, goychya vikasachi* (10 years of prosperity and development)'; and of course, taking potshots at the Congress and TMC.